

Operation Intercept 2025

Hidden Cargo – Write-Up

Challenge Title: Hidden Cargo

Category: Misc

Flag Format: K4P{word1_word2_word3_word4}

Description Recap

The challenge presented us with a series of graffiti-covered train boxcars, a cryptic voice memo, and the following riddle as a hint:

"Whisper to the winds -- let the first thought born of each etched whisper guide your path through the shadows."

And later, another important clue dropped:

"The red brother was the only one who knew the way."

These hints pointed toward an unconventional trail of clues hidden in the images themselves, disguised as **hobo signs**, symbols historically used by nomads to communicate danger, safety, or directions to fellow travelers.

Following the Clues

The final line, *"The red brother was the only one who knew the way,"* turned out to be a clever hint toward **Reddit** (the "Red Brother"), where we searched for the meanings behind the cryptic graffiti. There, we uncovered reference images and user posts decoding the **hobo signs** used in the challenge.

We carefully analyzed the train car images and identified four distinct symbols in the following order (based on timestamps in the image filenames):

1. **U-shaped curve**
2. **Three diagonal slashes (///)**
3. **Circle with a dot inside**
4. **Comb-like pattern**

P.s: Dont worry I will be attaching the images and the signs we discovered and also the audio transcript at the bottom of the page

The Interpretation

A major trap in this challenge was **overthinking the interpretation**. Our initial attempts used verbose or overly literal phrases like:

- K4P{safe_camp_near_water_move_on_quickly}
- K4P{dangerous_camp_beware_unsafe}

These were based on extended meanings, but the **format hint** told us to stick to a simpler structure:

"Let the first thought born of each etched whisper..."

This clearly pointed us toward using only the **first core word** from each symbol

Cross-referencing them with Reddit-sourced hobo sign charts, we derived the meanings:

- **Camp**
- **Unsafe**
- **Danger**
- **Beware**

These were used to construct the final flag.

The Final Flag

K4P{camp_unsafe_danger_beware}

A concise four-word flag — no extra words like "escape" or "phantom" were included, despite early speculation. The correct ordering came from the **timestamps on the image files**, and the **meanings came from Reddit** (aka "The Red Brother").

Reflections

This challenge stood out for its creativity. It wasn't just about technical skill — it demanded **observation, abstract thinking, and real-world knowledge** of forgotten communication methods like hobo signs. It reminded us how CTFs can sometimes blur the lines between hacking and cultural history.

We had a blast solving this one. Shoutout to HackKap and Hackviser for organizing Operation Intercept 2025 a memorable event with clever twists and tight competition.

Attachments,



Figure 1: 01-02-2024.png



Figure 2: 01-04-2022.png



Figure 3: 03-07-2024.png



Figure 4: 07-02-2023.png

Audio transcript;

“Log entry, let's see 9.56pm, Wednesday, July 30th, 2025, Analyst 3 here, and man, I'm half dead already. Phantom dumped these images on us.

Train box cars slatted in wild graffiti, and I'm starting to think there's something sneaky in there, maybe hidden in the colours.

Like, blended into the mess? I don't know, it's just a hunch. The file names are all timestamps, lined up like some crazy puzzle.

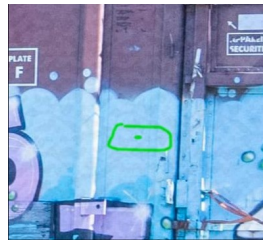
And I've been staring at it for hours. My eyes are crossing, honestly. Feels like the cartel's been using this, whatever it is, to pass secrets along the tracks.

And now Phantom's flipped it to send us a message. Oh, and Phantom's last words. Something about those who drift with the winds, or the travellers of old.

It's all fuzzy, but it might connect. Those graffiti colours though. I swear there's more to it, but I'm stumped. Maybe I'm just tired.

Gonna crash. Need someone else to crack this tomorrow.”

Hobo signs which were in those 4 pics;



HOBO SYMBOLS

kindhearted lady	woman	doctor no charge	housewife feeds for chores	food for work	you can sleep in the loft	keep quiet baby here	you'll get cursed out here
talk religion get food	bread	good for a handout	gentleman	kind gentleman lives here	I ate	allright (okay)	hold your tongue
home heavily guarded	tell pitiful story	tell a hard luck story	fake illness here	anything goes	sleep in barn	can sleep in barn	keep away
work available	good chance to get money here	here is the place	help if you are sick	beware thieves about	telephone	poor people live here	jail
bad tempered owner	dishonest person lives here	man with gun lives here	mean dogs here	bad dog	policeman lives here	courthouse or police station	dangerous man lives here
judge lives here	nothing doing here	doubtful	owner home	owner out	good road to follow	stop	good place to sleep
camp here	safe camp	bad water	good water good place to camp	hobos arrested on sight	cops active	cops inactive	beware! 4-dogs
good place to catch train	trolley	tramps here	no alcohol town (dry town)	town allows alcohol	go	I went this way	don't go this way
hit the road! quick!	get out fast	unsafe area	dangerous place	danger	afraid	unsafe place	be ready to defend yourself

Reference -

https://www.reddit.com/r/coolguides/comments/17f7h4d/a_cool_guide_to_modern_hobo_symbols/